CAREER

I Rejected 40 Data Analyst Candidates. Same 5 Mistakes Every Time

The 5 mistakes that end data analyst interviews, what each one looks like from the interviewer's side, and exactly what to do instead.

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Before the 5 mistakes

Most rejected candidates knew enough SQL and Excel. They lost on how they used it.

What interviewers are really checking

Can this person take a vague business question, get the right numbers, and explain what they mean?

Why skills alone do not save you

Two candidates write the same correct query. The one who explains why the result matters gets the offer.

How to use this PDF

For each mistake, read "what it looks like" and be honest about whether you do it.

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Mistake 1: You cannot explain your own project

The most common reason I stop an interview early.

What it looks like

"I used Python to clean the data and made a dashboard." Then silence when I ask why a chart was chosen or how missing values were handled.

Why it fails

It tells me the project was followed from a tutorial, not built.

Do this instead

For every project know: the question, the data size and source, the hardest cleaning step, one surprising finding, and what you would change.

Test yourself: explain your best project for 2 minutes without notes, to someone non-technical. Record it.

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Mistake 2: Writing SQL before asking a question

The task is "find our top customers". Most candidates start typing immediately.

What it looks like

Jumping straight to ORDER BY revenue DESC LIMIT 10.

Why it fails

Top by revenue, orders or profit? Which time period? Including returns? Real work starts with these questions.

Do this instead

Ask 2 or 3 clarifying questions, state your assumption out loud, then write the query.

Say this: "I will define top customers as highest net revenue in the last 12 months, excluding cancelled orders. Is that right?"

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Mistake 3: Never checking your own numbers

A wrong number delivered confidently is worse than no number.

What it looks like

The query returns ₹48 crore monthly revenue for a company that does ₹5 crore a year, and the candidate reads it out.

Why it fails

In the job, that number goes to a manager and gets used in a decision.

Do this instead

After every result, check: row count before and after joins, totals against a known figure, and whether the scale makes sense.

Habit: say "let me sanity check this" before you share any number. Interviewers notice.

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Mistake 4: A resume of tools, not results

I read the resume before the interview. This decides how hard I push.

What it looks like

"Skills: SQL, Python, Power BI, Excel, Tableau, Statistics." Project lines that only say what was used.

Why it fails

Everyone lists the same tools. Nothing tells me what you achieved.

Do this instead

Every line: action + tool + scale + result.

```
Built a Power BI sales dashboard for 40 managers,
cutting weekly reporting from 6 hours to 20
minutes.
```

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Mistake 5: No "so what"

The analysis is correct. The candidate stops at the chart.

What it looks like

"Sales in the South dropped 12% last quarter." End of answer.

Why it fails

Analysts are paid for what the business should do next, not for describing a chart.

Do this instead

Finish every answer with cause and action: what likely drove it, how you would confirm it, what you would recommend.

Formula: what happened → why it likely happened → what I would check → what I would recommend.

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Your fix-it checklist

Work through these before your next interview.

- **Project story ready**
  2-minute version and 30-second version, for each project.
- **Clarify before you code**
  Practise asking 2 questions before every SQL problem.
- **Sanity checks built in**
  Row counts, totals, scale. Every time.
- **Resume rewritten**
  Every line ends with a number.
- **"So what" in every answer**
  Close with a recommendation, not a description.

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